

Hypothesis and Imagination Series ①

4. The Third Method of Correlative Thinking – Gonggam (Empathy, 共感)

Confucian Logos: X is X, and -X is -X

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

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4.1. The Meaning of Empathic Thinking: The Universal Driving Force the West Borrowed and Changed the World With

In Chapter 3, through the Buddhist mythos (cyclicity), we confirmed that all things in heaven and earth are intimately bound in "relationship" as one vast organic web. However, the mere realization that everything is connected cannot substantively control real-world conflicts and threats (particularly the ethical challenges of artificial intelligence). Within the connected web of relationships, we must discern what is right and wrong—good and evil (善惡)—and establish a clear order (Logos). For this reason, thought necessarily passes through Daoism and Buddhism and moves on to the thinking of Gonggam (Empathy, 共感) in Chapter 3, which is completed upon the Confucian foundation of ethical standards and social responsibility.

We generally regard "empathy" as no more than a private disposition of emotionally sympathizing with another's sorrow. From a world-historical perspective, however, empathy (Sympathy/Empathy) was the immense driving force of a revolution that shook the world (Hwang Tae-yeon 2023). The Enlightenment thinkers of Europe (Leibniz, Voltaire, and others) translated and actively interpreted the Confucianism of the East, in particular the concepts of "ren" (仁)—regarding others as one's own body—and "seo" (恕, putting oneself in another's place). On this basis, they toppled the divine right of kings and invented the modern universal human rights premise that "all humans are equal, rational beings capable of empathizing with one another," thereby transforming the West and the entire world. The East itself, meanwhile, failed to realize how cosmic and modern its own Confucian thought was—how capable it was of dismantling the pre-modern order. In other words, true empathy at the dimension of Logos was the most powerful civilizational blueprint for reorganizing human society ethically and horizontally.

Empathy makes it possible for the same words to be received entirely differently depending on the listener's situation. Merely saying "It's okay" to a friend who failed an exam carries a different weight from saying, after listening fully to their

heart, "Next time let's prepare together." Empathy is precisely this power to read the temperature of a relationship.

AI can imitate emotional expression, but the agent that actually carries out responsible empathy is, as yet, the human being. That is why empathy is a human capacity that, the more technology advances, becomes all the more precious.

The third stage, "Gonggam (Empathy, 共感)," refers to the capacity for deep emotional immersion in others, resonance, and the formation of powerful communal bonds. It is the process of drawing out mutual connection and support by understanding and sharing the emotions of others. In the AI era, humans must shift, through a model of the "empathy economy" grounded in the awareness of "I-Here-Now," from isolated "rational actors" into "relational beings" rooted in community. Such an economy prizes the value of connection and of the present moment, and it foregrounds the distinctively human strength in that AI cannot experience genuine empathy. Humans are healed and find meaning through "story and communal connection." Storytelling is itself a "correlative act," one that creates meaning and fosters connection, especially when shared empathically.

A new human ontology sees the human as the "human as connecting being," one who bridges ideas, time, and people. Korea's traditional value of "jeong (情)" can, when combined with modern innovation, point toward a healthier social path. Because AI can imitate emotions but cannot truly "feel" or experience "qualia," the genuine empathic capacity of humans becomes an irreplaceable asset.

"Empathy" is not merely a "soft skill" but functions as a fundamental economic and social organizing principle of the AI era. As AI handles analytical tasks, human labor will increasingly concentrate on empathy-rich activities such as care, connection, and community-building. This signifies a re-evaluation of the "yin (陰)" aspect of the economy and society—that is, relational value—which is at present often undervalued. The success of this "empathy economy" depends on powerful "social capital" such as trust and goodwill.

The act of shared storytelling and narrative construction is a powerful and uniquely human mechanism for creating collective meaning and resilience, and it is indispensable for navigating the anxiety and uncertainty of the AI transition.

Story transforms "isolated, chaotic events" into a "meaningful, coherent sequence." Yet story must be accompanied by the practice of empathy. While AI can generate text, it cannot participate in the shared, embodied, empathic process of meaning-making. The emphasis on "empathy" requires a re-evaluation of leadership and power, demanding a shift from hierarchical command-and-control models to a more relational, empathic, and facilitative style. Leadership grounded in wisdom and empathy becomes important. This stands in contrast to the traditional power structures associated with a credentialist society.

4.2. Confucian (儒教) Logos

We have confirmed that empathy was the hidden driving force behind Western modernization, as well as a powerful tool for shattering artificial standards. Yet the more pluralistic and extremely chaotic the intelligent-information age becomes, the more paradoxically it requires firmer standards of good and evil and transparent social criteria. This is why we must, once again and urgently, summon a cool-headed, ethical Confucian Logos beyond compassionate mercy.

Unlike the two preceding propositions, this statement draws boundaries clearly. It is the attitude of saying that a thing is what it is (X) and what is not is what it is not (-X). This can be understood not as erasing differences, but as a mode of thought that seeks to set each thing rightly in its own place and role.

Taking the school as an example, the responsibility of a teacher and the responsibility of a student differ. Jest among friends and violence also differ, as do help and interference. If we say of everything that it is "all more or less the same," the community instead collapses. Logos emphasizes this ethics of distinction.

Therefore, "X is X, and -X is -X" does not mean exclusivity alone. It means that calling each being by its proper name and role is the starting point of order and respect.

Confucian Logos is a mode of thought that seeks to realize a harmonious social order by rightly establishing the principle (理) and the name/station (名) of things, and by fully discharging the proper way (道) according to each person's role and relationships. Regarding a friend (X) and an enemy (-X), Confucianism, unlike Daoism and Buddhism, says, "X is X, and -X is -X." That is, unlike Daoism, which says the enemy (-X) is a friend (X) and therefore one should love one's enemy, or Buddhism, which says there is neither friend (X) nor enemy (-X), Confucianism holds that a friend is a friend and an enemy is an enemy. The proposition "X is X, and -X is -X" means that each being must be faithful to its own essence and role (X) and must be clearly distinguished from what it is not (-X). In Confucianism, the ruler must be

ruler-like and the subject subject-like; study must be learned and practiced; a friend should come from afar; and one should revere one's own near parents above the distant parents of others. This reflects the rectification-of-names (正名論) perspective, which holds that an orderly and stable community can be achieved when each member of society knows and practices what they ought properly to do from their own position.

4.2.1. Reinterpreting Ren (仁): A New Ethics of Relationship

Ren (仁) is the core of humaneness in Confucianism—put simply, "the heart that regards the other as oneself." Where there is ren, one cannot simply pass by the suffering of another who differs from oneself. This heart is still needed in the AI era—indeed, needed all the more. When an AI algorithm produces a result that disadvantages a particular group, one cannot see the injustice without the sense of ren that asks, "How would it have been had I been in that position?"

When the principle of Logos—that X is X and $-X$ is $-X$ —is combined with ren (仁), the relational ethics of the AI era is completed: "acknowledge difference, but difference must not become discrimination." Men and women differ ($X \neq -X$), the old and the young differ, and persons with and without disabilities differ—yet ensuring that such difference does not lead to unjust discrimination within AI systems is the AI ethics of ren. To apply the sense of ren in the process of designing and reviewing AI systems means to examine outcomes from the standpoint of every person the algorithm affects.

Ren (仁), the core thought of Confucianism, is the essence of humaneness and the foundation of all relational ethics. Ren (仁) is grounded in love and consideration for others—that is, empathy and the heart of compassion (惻隱之心)—and it provides an important guide for establishing a new relational ethics in the AI era, between human and human, and between human and AI. Although AI can imitate human emotions, the true heart of ren (仁)—that is, the ethical subjectivity that empathizes with the suffering of others and voluntarily seeks to do good—is a domain unique to humans. Therefore, the relational ethics of the AI era must clearly distinguish ($X \neq -X$) the roles of human (X) and AI ($-X$), and must emphasize the ethical responsibility of humans to guide the use of AI in a direction that advances human dignity and the good (善) of the community.

4.2.2. Overcoming the "Han (恨)" of Technological Alienation

Ren (仁), the core thought of Confucianism, advances—in comparing humans with AI—to the concept of han (恨), which is unique to humans alone. Han (恨) is an emotion distinctive to Korea that is difficult to translate simply. It refers not to mere sorrow or anger, but to a deep-seated emotional state in which long-unresolved injustice and longing are intermingled. In the AI era, a new form of han is arising. The benefits of technology are concentrated in the few, while many who cannot keep pace with the speed of the digital transition are left behind amid feelings of alienation and deprivation. Rural elders, older adults unfamiliar with digital devices, and young people doing platform labor as irregular workers—these people bear the new han (恨) of the AI era.

Korean culture possesses the wisdom of resolving han not by simply suppressing it or letting it explode, but through "hanpuri" (the unraveling of han). From the perspective of Hwajaeng, the hanpuri of technological alienation is an institutional effort to invite alienated groups in as participants in the AI era. The expansion of digital education opportunities, intergenerational technology-sharing programs in which elders and youth take part together, and governance in which local communities together choose and make use of AI technology—such practices are the means of unraveling the han of technological alienation through Hwajaeng.

The rapid development of AI technology brings convenience and abundance to some classes, but on the other hand it can give rise to technological alienation through job loss, the deepening of the digital divide, and the like. Such feelings of alienation can leave a deep "han (恨)" in individuals and in society as a whole. The communal thought of Confucianism aims to overcome such technological alienation and to build a community of mutual flourishing (相生) in which all prosper together. This means creating an inclusive social system in which the benefits of AI technological development are distributed evenly across society as a whole, a social safety net is built so that no one is alienated by technology, and every member can participate in the process of technological development and share in its fruits—and this, too, is a domain unique to humans.

The following table presents a comparison of the empathy/postulate theories of Western philosophy (Kant, Hegel) and Eastern thought (Confucius, Buddhism). Kant may be compared with Buddhism, and Hegel with Confucianism.

Table 4-1. Comparison of Western Philosophy (Kant) and Eastern Thought (Buddhism)

Category	Kant (West)	Buddhism (East)
Moral principle	- Emphasis on a sense of duty and rational ought - Does not regard help through compassion as moral - "Postulates" for realizing the highest good (immortality of the soul, freedom, God)	- The thought of Dependent Origination (緣起) and Emptiness (空) - Compassion (慈悲) and non-self (無我) - The interconnectedness of all beings
Concept of empathy	- Emphasis on moral action based on "duty" and "respect" rather than direct "empathy" - "Postulate" as a concept arising from the necessity of practical reason	- A practical attitude of empathizing with others' suffering through "compassion" and seeking to relieve it - Enhanced empathic capacity through understanding that all people are changing beings - Ease of conflict resolution
Implications for the AI era	- Considering the non-emotional nature of AI, the need to explore the limits of human "rational ethics" and transcendent values - The importance of setting a "regulative principle" for the problem of AI's judgmental bias	- Foregrounding the importance of "relational intelligence" and "interdependence" in the AI era - A survival strategy that acknowledges AI's imperfection and works through human "spiritual transcendence" and "inner reflection"

Table 4-2. Comparison of Western Philosophy (Hegel) and Eastern Thought (Confucius)

Category	Hegel (West)	Confucius (East)
Moral principle	- Dialectical self-realization (thesis-antithesis-synthesis) - Views contradiction as the driving force of development - Stages of ethical life (family, civil society, state)	- Emphasis on moral virtues such as ren (仁) and li/propriety (禮) - Self-completion through self-cultivation (修身) - Emphasis on self-reflection and practice

Category	Hegel (West)	Confucius (East)
Concept of empathy	- Overcoming isolated existence through "love," forming a unified self-consciousness of self and other - Reflection on relationship through the dialectical process	- Empathic capacity such as the "heart of compassion" as the core of "ren (仁)" - Possessing a system of projecting the meaning of others through "empathy"
Implications for the AI era	- Understanding the "contradictory relationship" between AI and humans as a "driving force of development" - Emphasis on "holistic" problem-solving capacity through collaboration with AI - The importance of "relational" understanding and "communication" needed for leadership in the AI era	- Re-emphasis on "empathy" and "character education" as the core of "humaneness" in the AI era - Leadership of a "warm heart" and "empathic power" that AI cannot replace

4.3. The Art of Relationship: Beomjeol (凡節)

We have confirmed that Confucian Logos is a universal measure for reconstructing humanity and a framework of ethics. This macroscopic philosophical foundation must not remain empty talk with one's head in the clouds; it must live and breathe as manners and institutions within our concrete daily lives. The practical etiquette and norms of a new era—one in which AI agents and humans will live in daily contact—that is, "beomjeol (凡節)," are now to be newly designed.

Logos connects to beomjeol. This is, in every case, a domain unique to embodied humans. Beomjeol (凡節) refers to the etiquette and norms that keep relationships between people running smoothly. In the AI era, a new form of beomjeol is needed. Whether one must turn on the camera in a video conference, whether one may submit AI-generated writing as one's own, whether one must obtain permission before posting another person's photo on social media—in such new situations, society must together determine what constitutes courteous behavior.

The core of AI etiquette is transparency. Not passing on AI-generated information without verifying its source, and not using AI to manipulate or deceive others—this is the foundation of beomjeol in the AI era. The principle at the heart of Confucian Logos—"call names rightly" (rectification of names, 正名)—remains valid in the AI era as well.

Beomjeol (凡節) refers to etiquette and social norms in everyday life, and it is an essential element for smooth human relationships and harmonious communal living. As AI enters deeply into human life, new norms and etiquette—that is, the "beomjeol of the AI era"—are becoming necessary for interactions between humans and AI as well.

4.3.1. Defining Roles and Responsibilities

In the AI era, not only relationships between humans but also the establishment of relationships between humans and AI emerges as an important task. It is necessary to clearly define the scope of AI's roles and capabilities, as well as where responsibility lies for AI's actions. Humans, as the agents who develop and use AI, must bear ethical responsibility, and AI

must be used in a direction that promotes human welfare under human control and supervision. Furthermore, humans must make efforts to prevent misunderstandings or conflicts that may arise in interactions with AI, and to form healthy relationships grounded in mutual respect and understanding.

4.3.2. Rebuilding Trust: Empathy Capital

Trust is the invisible glue that keeps society running smoothly. When people trust one another, transaction costs fall, cooperation becomes easier, and creative attempts become possible. In the AI era, this trust faces new threats. Fake videos created by deepfakes, false information generated by AI, and biased worldviews produced by algorithms all have the power to undermine the trust between people. Rebuilding trust is one of the most urgent social tasks of the AI era.

Empathy capital is a social asset accumulated through the capacity for empathy. The memory of having been helped when in difficulty, the experience of having had one's heart truly understood, the history of having weathered hardship together—these form empathy capital. Like money saved in a bank, this capital is invisible, yet it is the real power that enables a community to endure together in a moment of crisis. If AI can raise efficiency and speed, empathy capital is the distinctively human capacity for recovery that mends the social fractures AI creates.

Cultivating empathy capital at school is possible even without special programs. Listening sincerely to a friend's presentation, consciously including a friend who has been left out, and first hearing out one another's positions when a conflict arises—these small practices build empathy capital. This later becomes the foundation for creating a truly humane organization when working alongside AI in society.

The development of AI technology offers convenience, but at the same time it carries risk factors that can undermine social trust, such as invasion of personal information, algorithmic bias, and the spread of false information. Therefore, in the AI era, it is important to rebuild a healthy trust grounded in critical thinking rather than blind trust in technology. To this end, we must enhance the transparency and explainability of AI systems, adhere to ethical principles in the process of developing and using AI, and establish social oversight and regulation to prevent the misuse of technology.

Furthermore, we must accumulate "empathy capital" grounded in the distinctively human capacity for empathy, and through it promote mutual understanding and cooperation so as to strengthen the foundation of social trust.

4.4. Yokdae (浴帶) and the Discernment of Good and Evil: The Final Line of Defense Distinguishing AI from Humans

In the Twelve Life-Cycle Stages, the human who has come into the world through "yangsaeng" inevitably meets the stage of "yokdae (浴帶)." Yokdae literally means "to bathe and gird oneself with a sash," and it signifies, beyond merely covering the body, the establishment of an ethical identity that puts on the garment of social norms and begins to distinguish the good and evil (善惡) of the world.

It is precisely this characteristic of "yokdae" that is the core of the empathy toward which Confucian Logos aims. Empathy, beyond simply weeping together, is the act of weightily judging—within the web of relationships—what is right and what leads humanity to ruin (good and evil). Artificial intelligence (AI), on the basis of humanity's enormous data, can "output" sorrowful sentences in tune with the sound of weeping. Yet because AI does not possess the substantive body of suffering (yangsaeng), it cannot undergo the process of "yokdae"—of bathing and purifying oneself and girding on the ethical sash (the bone-deep embodiment of good and evil). In the coming age of extremes, the sole and most powerful practical weapon capable of distinguishing and controlling soulless machine algorithms from humans is precisely "the capacity to discern good and evil through empathy."

From the perspective of Hwajaeng, the establishment of identity is not "choosing a single real self." Rather, it is discovering, while acknowledging the many faces of oneself, a core value that does not waver in any situation. The self that laughs together with friends is me, the self that agonizes alone is me, and the self that receives AI's help is me—but what one holds important when making a choice, that value system, is the true center of identity. Finding this center is the most important developmental task of young people in the AI era.

Yokdae (浴帶), in the Eastern stages of human development, refers to the period of first stepping into society and, within relationships with others, testing and establishing one's own identity. Individuals in the AI era must form their identity within a complex social environment where the virtual and the real are intermingled and diverse information and value systems collide. What matters in this process is forging social relationships through genuine empathy and communication with others, and finding one's role and meaning within the community. We must recognize that while AI can be a tool for access to information and for communication, genuine socialization and the establishment of identity are achieved through human interaction and experience.